

OCCUPATIONAL THERAPIST



JOB DESCRIPTION

Occupational therapists use individual treatment programs, exercise, and psychological therapies to help people overcome problems caused by disability, illness, injury, or aging. The therapist trains patients to carry out daily tasks so they can lead full, independent lives.



SALARY

Occupational therapy assistant ★★★★★
Occupational therapy manager ★★★★★

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Rising demand for occupational therapists • Majority of work in government-sector areas, such as health and social service • Job opportunities worldwide

AT A GLANCE



YOUR INTERESTS Biology • Health and social service • Psychology • Social sciences • Supporting people with mobility problems



ENTRY QUALIFICATIONS A graduate degree in occupational therapy is required. You must also pass the national exam and apply for state licensure.



LIFESTYLE Most therapists work regular hours, but some work shift patterns. Part-time and flexible work options are also available.



LOCATION Occupational therapists work in hospitals, prisons, at social service offices, and in private practices. They may travel to visit their patients.



THE REALITIES Some patients can be challenging. Occupational therapists need physical strength and agility, as well as patience and a sense of humor.

RELATED CAREERS

- ▶ **PSYCHOLOGIST** *see pp. 254–255*
- ▶ **SOCIAL WORKER** *see pp. 258–259*
- ▶ **SPEECH PATHOLOGIST** *see pp. 290–291*
- ▶ **HEARING THERAPIST** Works with adults and children who are experiencing hearing loss, hearing disturbances, and balance problems. Hearing therapists mainly work in hospitals and health centers where they assess patients and develop treatment plans.
- ▶ **MASSAGE THERAPIST** Provides patients and clients massages to relieve any physical discomforts, enhance general well-being, and treat specific muscular problems, such as spasms and sprains. A massage therapist also uses their skills to provide relief to people with long-term illnesses or sports injuries.
- ▶ **OCCUPATIONAL HEALTH NURSE** Promotes better health and well-being in the workplace, usually as part of a health and safety team.